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3 authors:

Manica Danko
University of Ljubljana

Damijana Keržič
University of Ljubljana

Žiga Kotnik
University of Ljubljana

PEER OBSERVATION IN HIGHER EDUCATION AS AN AGENT OF CHANGE IN TEACHING AND LEARNING

Manica Danko, Damijana Keržič, Žiga Kotnik

University of Ljubljana, Faculty of Administration (SLOVENIA)

Abstract

Peer observation is an element of development towards the enhancement of quality of teaching and learning in higher education (HE). In the process of pedagogical observation teachers empower self-reflection on their pedagogical practice, identify good practices observed and establish communication about teaching with their colleagues. The inclusion of students in the observation practice increases the awareness of student experience in teaching and learning practice, which fosters the introduction of improvements in teaching and learning. In the 2014/15 academic year a pilot project of peer observation of teaching (POT) at the Faculty of Administration (FA), University of Ljubljana, investigated the perceptions of teachers and students about pedagogical process. The aim of the project was to find out how both parties experience the process and what they detect as strengths, weaknesses or opportunities for improvements in the teaching and learning process. The survey compared the observations in order to find what both groups recognize as important elements of teaching practice and possible similarities and differences in their observations. The results of the survey suggest that advantages of POT are multifold: it is not only the feedback on teaching from colleagues and students but also the process of planning strategies to address areas for improvements in teaching and learning. Students as partners in the process are empowered by the ability to recognize the academic excellence in teaching and learning and thus become responsible for the improvements in the pedagogical culture of an institution.

Keywords: peer observation, higher education, pedagogy, teaching, qualitative content analysis

1 INTRODUCTION

The European HE area defines pedagogical excellence as an important aspect of quality assurance in education. It stresses the fact that only quality teaching and learning environment encourages students to acquire knowledge, skills and competences needed to compete successfully in the labour market after graduation. In the report on the Modernisation of Higher Education in Europe [1] the High Level Group of the European Commission suggests that improving the quality of teaching and learning does not need huge amounts of funding but rather a change of culture and emphasizes that it requires flexible and innovative approaches.

As HE institutions should balance the preference of research over teaching, the above report suggests that HE institutions should strive towards connecting research and teaching. There is no contradiction between the imperative of good teaching and the imperative of research, therefore the quality of teaching and learning practices should be a priority in establishing academic excellence in HE. Only quality teaching and learning in HE is crucial for ensuring that students acquire the right blend of skills for their future personal and professional development. The acquisition depends on committed individuals and dedicated institutions, supported by policies that map teaching and learning at the centre of their efforts.

In order to put teaching in the centre of attention and to promote the idea that all teachers in higher education should be taught how to teach, in the report of the Commission 16 recommendations for improving quality in teaching and learning have been set. The FA adopted the suggestions from the report in their pilot project of POT. Among 16 recommendations, the following were the focus of our attention in establishing a solid rationale for the project.

Recommendation 2: Every institution should develop and implement a strategy for the support and on-going improvement of the quality of teaching and learning, devoting the necessary level of human and financial resources to the task, and integrating this priority in its overall mission, giving teaching due parity with research.

Recommendation 3: Higher education institutions should encourage, welcome, and take account of student feed-back which could detect problems in the teaching and learning environment early on and lead to faster, more effective improvements.

Recommendation 5: Academic staff entrance, progression and promotion decisions should take account of an assessment of teaching competence alongside other factors.

Recommendation 8: Student performance in learning activities should be assessed against clear and agreed learning outcomes, developed in partnership by all faculty members involved in their delivery.

Recommendation 10: Higher education institutions should introduce and promote cross-, trans- and inter-disciplinary approaches to teaching, learning and assessment, helping students develop their breadth of understanding and entrepreneurial and innovative mindsets.

The chosen recommendations fitted into the framework for the project of POT with the suggestions from the report that "giving teaching due parity with research, taking account of student feed-back, assessing of teaching competence, focusing on clear and agreed learning outcomes and introducing and promoting cross-, trans- and inter-disciplinary approaches to teaching".

POT in HE worldwide is implemented for institutional or national evaluation of teaching in HE institution in the process of quality assurance procedures and for the purpose of evaluation in accreditation processes. It could be part of the ongoing evaluation of the teacher's performance and may be implemented in decisions on promotion, tenure or remuneration policies. In the process of POT teacher observes pedagogical activities (lecture or tutorial) of his colleague as part of an agreement between teachers in order to extend the observation with the exchange of observations of teaching and suggestions for further improvements and possible partnership in a post-observation session. One of the possible benefits of POT may also be a demonstration of good practice for the fellow teacher(s) to observe and incorporate into their own teaching.

The pilot POT project at the FA, University of Ljubljana was designed primarily as friendly exchange of observations and ideas, recognition of good practice and, above all, the empowerment of students as stakeholders in raising the awareness of how they can recognize and benefit from a good teaching and learning process.

2 PEER OBSERVATION OF TEACHING

In the first place, POT is a reflection on teacher's work and how its results could influence student learning. We investigated the available literature on POT to gain some insight into what had already been discovered through the experience of POT in HE elsewhere. Various authors report that POT is an efficient method in the professional development of HE teachers. Bell [2] suggests that it can be conducted in an informal manner as an agreement between peer teachers or as a formal system of monitoring teacher performance during the trial period or as a tool for identifying weaknesses in their teaching. Shortland [3] understands POT as part of development programmes for both new lecturers and established staff offering a great potential for teachers to promote self-knowledge and personal growth when it is part of a continuing process. For Gosling [4] POT is a powerful learning experience, part of a training course for new lecturers or as part of a development process for individual lecturers or the whole department. POT can establish a 'safe' place where discussions about teaching can take place. The author stresses the idea that besides teaching other observable activities need to be addressed in POT: student feedback, assessment processes, student learning outcomes and learning materials.

Donnely [5] suggests that teaching in HE has become complex and demanding due to the changing role of and purpose of HE in the process of marketization of knowledge production in a global economy. This implies diversity of disciplines, increasing demands of students, course design delivery, which claims new teaching and learning strategies. The author recommends that the process of POT is talking about, disseminating and developing the good practice in learning and teaching in a positive climate of dialogue and open debate about good teaching and learning. Teachers need to experience different ideas and methods in various situations of their own teaching by taking risks in implementing them and reflect critically on them with the help of their colleagues' feedback on teaching. In the process POT teachers learn both through receiving feedback and by watching the teaching of others.

The activity of observation in POT process could be just as beneficial as receiving feedback. Hendry and Oliver [6] provide evidence that in an introductory program for new full-time academics, participants proved that POT strengthens the self-efficacy of teachers to apply new strategies to their own teaching. Being observed, some felt like they were being judged, while in observing, they could judge for themselves what could be useful or not in terms of both their own and the students' reactions. The main benefit of POT is while watching someone teach well, it inspires us to try the strategy, and when we are successful, we believe that what we saw and what we are capable of is strengthened. The authors suggest that reciprocal POT between teachers who have not established a positive rapport is not desirable as this may make the one observed nervous or even exposed.

According to Harris et al. [7] teachers who were involved in POT found it beneficial to be able to watch other teachers and thus recognize the different methods of teaching. This provided them with new ideas for their own classes and gave them positive reinforcement about their own methods. POT is about learning through observation, rather than just concentrating on the feedback received by the observing teacher.

Lasagabaster and Sierra [8] discuss that the observed teachers express their positive attitude regarding POT and believe that the advantages of observation outweigh the disadvantages. Regarding the teachers' likes and dislikes, the authors stress that some teachers will be unwilling to take part in POT, in most cases due to unease and anxiety or the feeling of being assessed. The authors highlight the aspects that provide invaluable advice for POT design.

In POT:

- friendly, supportive environment is needed;
- observer does not affect the class;
- objectives and procedures are agreed in advance;
- feedback is constructive and objective;
- observer is skilled in observation techniques, familiar with the subject;
- co-ordination between the observer and the observed is essential;
- the process is classroom reality;
- process is systematic to avoid a distortion of class activity;
- benefits are tangible;
- participation is voluntary.

Cosh [9] argues that the POT is done in order to reflect upon teaching in a feeling of mutual trust and respect between the colleagues and develop actively rather than make judgements upon others. Only teachers acquainted with the protocol, the time, the purpose, the goals and the form of feedback will be empowered by the feeling of command and self-control in the process of POT. Two observations per year are suggested: one with a teacher in a similar area and the second in a different one, if possible. The observation protocol with a feedback form is to be agreed, which enables the observer to note down the observations about what has been learnt. Thinking about teaching and learning can lead to action research, further discussions or examination of the relevant theory.

Martin and Double [10] see the advantages of POT in the enhancement of collaboration between teachers and in building their professional and interpersonal skills through giving feedback on the areas of expertise and possible improvements in teaching. In collaboration with colleagues, teachers develop their competences in the ability to plan teaching and learning activities pertaining to various needs of students, which may enhance their learning experience. Collaboration in POT eventually boosts the flexibility in thinking about changes that teachers implement in their teaching and raises the awareness that POT is relevant even in the design and delivery of study programmes. Such collaborative peer observation practice between colleagues can eventually evolve in a 'critically friend' relationship that establishes the opportunity for constructive feedback about weaknesses or problems that could sometimes be uncomfortable or difficult to hear.

The findings from the literature discussed were considered in the preparation of POT project at the FA. Bearing in mind the three models according to Gosling: a 'management model' (senior staff observe other staff), a 'development model' (educational developers or expert teachers observe practitioners) and in a 'peer review model' (teachers observe each other), for purpose of the FA POT project the last one has been chosen. The peer review model was adopted and designed as a three-part activity: pre-observation session, observation and post-observation reflective session, devised by Martin and Double [10]. Such model is based on collegial observation with the purpose of describing observations rather than evaluating the teaching and learning process, which was the fundamental purpose of our project.

3 PEER OBSERVATION OF TEACHING AT THE FACULTY OF ADMINISTRATION

The Faculty of Administration is a member of the University of Ljubljana. It provides the quality study, research, counselling and training in the field of public administration. Students are offered interdisciplinary 1st and 2nd cycle university study programmes in public sector governance and higher educational professional study programme in public administration. The programmes comprise the courses that deal with the main areas of public administration study: legal regulation, development and organisation of public administration, public sector economics and public finance, management in public sector, informatisation and development of e-government. The quality of study has been recognized by the accreditation of EAPAA (European Association for Public Administration Accreditation) for two first-cycle and one second-cycle study programmes.

In the Strategy 2014−2020 the FA stipulates that the teaching and learning process requirement is to increase the number of HE teachers who meet the standards of academic excellence. Since the student survey is the only source for teaching quality evaluation as no other instruments for the evaluation of teaching is agreed on the institutional level. The irony of academic milieu is supported by the fact that every relevant piece or academic writing in research or publishing is mandatory peer-reviewed, which can not be established in HE teaching. Lecture rooms are still tightly sealed, observation-proof places, and the culture of peer observation, collaboration or team teaching is still in its beginnings. Although European HE area promotes the idea that institutions should promote teaching, much is left to individual institutions. Teaching and learning in HE is still the most important activity that guarantees the existence of HE institutions in Slovenia.

One of possible activities that can boost the academic excellence is POT with the possibility to establish the dialogue between the interested stakeholders: teachers and students.

The Centre for the Development of Pedagogical Excellence at the FA took the initiative in starting the POT project after some workshops on innovative teaching and learning methods in HE had been held. Mostly informal debates about teaching (teaching methods, learning outcomes, competences, assessment, student motivation, etc.) spread the interest for HE pedagogy, which led to the inquiry into what effective teaching practices are.

In the 2013/14 academic year a framework for a voluntary mini POT was designed based on the intention to set a model for POT to be upgraded in the following year. The rationale for POT with a short literature review of teaching observation practice, its purpose, goals and benefits were presented to the FA staff. Only a few teachers who took part in it were enthusiastic and had therefore established a companionship through mutual interest in promoting the idea of POT. Students were included in the observation as well.

What had been recognized as important aspects of POT during the first trial was implemented in the upgraded project in the 2014/15 academic year:

- pre-observation meeting is essential for the establishment of rapport between partners (topic, expected learning outcomes, familiarisation with the subject);
- mission of observer is introduced to students;
- students need to know the purpose and goals of POT;
- POT covers the time of the whole teaching activity (lecture, tutorial);
- observation covers various aspects of teaching activity;
- do not evaluate, judge or assess, but describe;
- it is necessary to train observers how to maintain unbiased position and how to conduct feedback session in a friendly and relaxed atmosphere.

The three-part observation model was used again in 2014/15 voluntary POT project with some changes in the selection of observation tasks for teachers and students.

4 OBSERVATION FORM

An observation form for observes (teachers and students) was designed to gather data about teaching (lectures or tutorials) based on the aspects of observation dealt with in the literature. In this survey, a lecture is given to a cohort of students to teach them about more theoretical aspects of a course, whereas a tutorial is, in the case of the FA, activities of a teaching assistant with a group of students (up to 50) working on more practical aspects of the course. The POT project aimed at developing the ability of teachers to reflect on one’s teaching through observation and give feedback on it while learning from the process. The project also tried to let students express what their perspective on some aspects of teaching is as they may be able to describe the teaching process but would not be able to provide any informed suggestions how this could be improved [7].

The anonymous observation form for students contains nine open-ended questions on various aspects of observation. In open-ended questions they identify strong and weak points of teaching and state what they think the teacher might do about improving their teaching. Students state if they have learnt anything by recognizing the objectives of teaching. In the last question they define if there is anything in what teacher does worth imitating. In one of them students draw a line on a graph representing the level of their motivation in the dynamic learning process. They mark three points on the line to identify the three main events that represent the crucial moments in the change of the pace of the process.

The observation form for teachers contains comparable aspects of observation in open-ended questions. The survey is interested in how similar or different the perception of teaching process of teachers and students are. The first pre-observation part contains general questions (study programme, academic year, course name, number of students, topic, teaching objectives and outline of teaching).

In the observation part teachers observers define three crucial points on the motivation line and describe what happens each time. In the introduction to teaching part they describe if/how teaching objectives are presented to students, how they relate to previous teaching and if teacher checks what has been learnt so far. Teachers also describe the teaching method (lecture, seminar, tutorial, case study…) employed and the participation of students (asking questions, taking part in discussion…). Teacher’s communication (speech, audibility, enthusiasm, clear answers…) with students, the tempo and the resources used (literature…) are also observed. In the form observers also define if teaching objectives were achieved and how teacher evaluated them. In their final observations teachers state if it is obvious that students know what they have learnt. In a more personal reflection they explain what inspired them, what they have learnt, what they will or not use in their teaching or what opportunities for improvement are and what could be done otherwise.

5 METHOD AND RESULTS

Student and teacher observation forms data were analysed using a qualitative content analysis (QCA) which is an established method for structuring qualitative data [11]. It is a technique for compressing many words of text into fewer content categories based on explicit rules of coding. The analysis itself does not indicate whether something is good or bad, appropriate or inappropriate, but it shows only "what" is written or said, but not for what purpose, by whom and how. We defined the occurrence of certain words when describing specific questions of observation forms. The chosen words were further grouped in semantic relevant categories. Only those words with the replication frequency at least 8 in the observation forms were considered significant and added in applicable categories.

In the POT project 14 teachers voluntarily joined in order to participate as observees or observers. The data analysis was conducted with 24 teacher observation forms and 170 student observation forms (see Table 1).

Table 1: Number of observation forms

	Observing teachers	Students
Lectures	15	97
Tutorials	9	73
Total	24	170

Source: Research.

5.1 Teacher observation forms

The data from the teacher observation form focuses on teachers’ reflection on one’s teaching and their feedback on it while learning from the process. Teacher observation form covers the four aspects of observation, namely:

1. curve representing the flow of activities in lectures or tutorials,
2. introduction into lectures or tutorials,

3. central part of lectures or tutorials,
4. concluding activities in lectures or tutorials
5. concluding/summarising observations of teachers in observation forms.

5.1.1 Curve representing the flow of lectures or tutorials

During observation teachers draw a curve representing the flow/dynamics of the teaching in progress. Watching students' reactions, they mark points that seem important and note down what, in their opinion, triggers either high or low motivation of students.

All observers detect high motivation of the students observed when they are actively involved in the teaching process, answering questions, solving problems or participating in debate. Their motivation also increases when teacher includes real-life examples that students are familiar with or when teacher highlights and summarizes the content relevant to exam.

Students' low motivation can be observed when too much information (text) on a single slide (PowerPoint presentation) is read to them, particularly after a long period of monotonous lecturing without any active participation of students. In tutorials, the attention drops to a very low level at the very beginning of tutorial when teaching assistants "re-lecture" the content that has previously been lectured by course teacher.

5.1.2 Introduction of lectures or tutorials

At the beginning of a lecture or tutorial, observers try to recognise the manner in which teacher presents objectives of lectures or tutorials and whether they involve students in the summarisation of the substance of the previous lecture.

Only 3 teachers out of 14 do not mention any objectives being observed. The beginning of lecture or tutorial a brief repetition of key concepts of previous lectures is often observed. It involves students who are asked questions to be engaged in the process.

5.1.3 Central part of lectures and tutorials

The central part of the teacher observation form includes various aspects of lectures or tutorials.

1. **Communication with students/active participation of students.** Active student participation is reported when teacher supports a question with a practical example. As students' answers in lectures are often very short, teachers usually complete their thoughts in order to provide explanation for the rest of them. During tutorials active participation of students occurs more often as methods employed involve individual or team work stimulating independent investigation of study materials and reporting pair of group work results in a debate.

2. **Teaching material.** Almost all teachers use PowerPoint presentations in their lectures. They use board for drawing mind maps or specific terms use, printed worksheets or excerpts from articles, ICT (video, cell phones for online quiz or material prepared in e-classroom).

3. **Pace/dynamics**. Observers report the pace of lectures or tutorials as too fast, just right or too slow. A very fast pace has demotivating effects on students which can be observed in their inability to take active part in discussion or make notes. In other cases a slow pace or monotony in the delivery of lecture reveal students' disinterest in the lecture (chat, use of mobile phones, body language displaying disinterest, etc.) which is sometimes caused by teacher's monotonous reading form slides without any interaction with students.

4. **Inspired teaching**. Observers recognise confidence in teaching, demonstration of expertise and subject knowledge, spontaneity in behaviour, ability to link theory and current practice with illustrative as worth imitating in their own teaching. Teachers who encourage students in active participation, use group work and students as demonstrators, check the understanding of substance using ICT are considered as role models. The ability to systematically organise tutorials is particularly appreciated.

Analysis reveals that teachers who can facilitate a thorough debate on a topic with great enthusiasm, illustrative practical examples to substantiate their argument or explain a particular theory term, are also very inspiring. A good teacher is the one who intervenes timely when students are unfocused and points out a particular student when asking a question. A good teacher also points out where and why students need specific knowledge and competences.

5. **What should be changed?** Bearing in mind a more critical aspect, the observees notice many challenges and opportunities for improvements in the teaching process.

They miss more active student participation and suggest that is could be increased by different seating arrangements. Oversized classrooms do not provide good opportunity to establish contact and active students' participation.

Many tutorials adopt a form of lectures without any genuine participation of students, which leads to students' demotivation. The repetition of subject matter from the last lecture, done by the tutorial mentor, is often pointless when it does not include students. In post observational sessions observees suggest that student participation should be activated in forms of homework reports or debate about subject matter empowering students' ability to argue, defend or justify their positions. In relatively small tutorial groups assistant teachers could call their students by names, call them out to complete pictures on the board or establish some other form of communication and boost their participation. This could mean that even very shy students would get their opportunity. Such cases have always been reported as beneficial by students. In-tutorial assignments should comprise more individual tasks to boost and challenge independent learning in order to make students responsible to create their own knowledge. Tutorials are suggested to provide thorough feedback on assignments done during tutorials to students which can be done in the existing e-classrooms.

5.1.4 Concluding activities in lectures and tutorials

The concluding activities within lectures and tutorials focus on summarising of the subject matter lectured and learnt in the way of verification if students achieved the objectives or learning outcomes desired.

Usually a brief summary is done, supported with keywords in PowerPoint presentation or on board, occasionally with implications for the next week lecture. Observees suggest that more attention is to be paid to checking whether the goals and learning outcomes of the lesson have been achieved by short quizzes (employing e.g. remote-control like devices called clickers) or other forms of student activity. Many observees stressed the necessity for students to be included in summarising the key points of the lesson in one way or another and prove to the teacher and themselves that the knowledge has been acquired.

5.1.5 Concluding/summarising observations of teachers in observation forms

In the observation form teachers state their final impressions and remarks about the lectures they experienced. They point out the following:

- Using PowerPoint presentation as a presentation tool in lectures is excessive.
- In case of existing course textbooks, cases and examples used in classroom teaching should not be only those stated in textbooks.
- Textbook is not the only source of knowledge used in classroom lecture.
- Objectives that are rarely presented at the beginning, should be clearly stated at the beginning and evaluated at the end by adding what has been done, learnt, or relevant for final assessment.
- Checking prior knowledge is too sporadic. Usually it is the teacher who sums up the substance, therefore students need to be exposed to it on regular basis throughout lecture.
- Using mobile phones for private reasons is disturbing as it distracts students' and teacher's attention. They could be used for learning purposes systematically in line with the activities in class.
- Active participation and learning by making notes is hindered if students get access to study material in advance (copies of PowerPoint slides used by teacher in class in e-classroom, photocopies obtained by peers). Taking notes can be beneficial for processing information and reframing it later in one's own words.
- PowerPoint presentations should be prepared with more care and appropriate amount of text, aiming at active participation of students along their use. The text should not be read by teacher.
- The drawbacks observed in teaching are mainly pointed out in reference to poor active participation of students. Teacher should strive to involve students by posing interesting question, calling them randomly and in person to answer a question, or using debate, role playing, pro et contra, or any other adequate pedagogical method that stimulate students' participation.

Some recommendations for improvements in tutorials have been suggested:

- Students should be encouraged to participate actively (in front of class to get used to perform in public) and less should be done by teachers.
- Students should be stimulated to provide extensive answers (one or two words are not enough), teachers are not to complete their unfinished answers.
- It is necessary to intervene among students that distract the teaching process with their disruptive behaviour.
- Questions (energizers) that could help raise the attention should be incorporated more often.
- Too much time is spent on revision of previous lecture, especially if this is done by teacher through monologue without any participation of students.
- Making handwritten notes during class is to be promoted.
- Planning students work in classroom activities in advance to facilitate more independent student work, allowing students some ‘creativity’.

The observing teachers especially stress that more attention should be paid to the clear structuring of teaching process into several subsections: introduction in the topic, the lecture, interactive group work/debate, revision of the key points and the acquired knowledge of students and time for Q&A session at the end or during class.

5.2 Student observation forms

The following aspects of observation were investigated:

1. three crucial moments,
2. most important parts of lectures or tutorials,
3. strengths and weaknesses of lectures or tutorials,
4. opportunities for improvement,
5. what could be done differently,
6. achievement of lectures or tutorials objectives,
7. what is worth imitating,
8. possible future improvements.

Students’ observation forms are analysed in detail below.

1. **Three crucial moments.** The reasons why student motivation is either sustained or obstructed are as follows. The analysis of students’ observation forms suggest that the point of maximum motivation is achieved in the following cases: at the beginning of the lesson, when the formal instructions related to the course are presented, when students are invited to participate in the debate, during teamwork, when teacher presents practical examples, or when ICT was used.

The analysis reveals that the lowest point of student motivation is achieved: after 45 minutes in shorter activities, after 1.5 hour in block hours, 20 minutes before the end, when a large amount of information is given in a very short time, when the pace of teaching is too fast, or when teacher repeats the previously lectured content.

2. **Most important parts of the lectures or tutorials.** The most important parts suggested by students are: teacher’s interpretation of current events and practices, a case study, when theory supported by practice and use of scientific methods in solving real-life situations. In some cases it has been reported that the revision of previously lectured content could be important too. Analysis of scientific papers during the teaching process and active student participation are also very important point in students’ minds.

3. **Strengths and weaknesses of lectures or tutorials.** The analysis reveals that the strong points of lectures or tutorials constitute a debate between teacher and students, the time for students' questions and teacher's answers, clearly and interestingly presented current practical examples supported by video, practical assignments that promote students’ active participation, an energetic teacher with positive attitude and a teacher who is well prepared for class.

Among the weaker points of lectures students expose parts of lectures or tutorials when extensive information is given at once and when too many new terms unfamiliar to students are used. In students’ opinion too many questions without answers are considered to be a weak point of a lecture or tutorial. Lectures or tutorials are considered weak, where not enough time is devoted to the analysis of specific cases, when the instructions for solving problems are insufficient or inaccurate, when a topic is presented in an uninteresting way, when lecture has no red thread, when a teacher skips from topic to topic and when the pace of lecture is too fast which makes students impossible to and make good notes.

4. **Opportunities for improvement.** Opportunities for improvement could be implemented by the delivery of real-life case studies and the inclusion of multimedia in a learning process. Students also suggest that PowerPoint presentations should be better prepared and that one of the aspects that needs more attention is a low level of students' active participation in class, especially during tutorials.

5. **What could be done differently?** Students believe that several short breaks can help students stay more focused during lessons. They also suggest that publishing study material prior to lectures and tutorials online would allow students to prepare for class in advance.

6. **Achievement of lectures or tutorials objectives**. The majority of students recognized the achievement of objectives of lectures and tutorials. A small number of them claim that the objectives were not met or can nor reply. Despite the high share of positive answers, the analysis showed that students poorly recognize what learning outcomes and objectives of lectures and tutorials are.

The vast majority of students recognize that objectives are achieved in cases when teacher gives an interesting lecture, when students can follow lecture and make notes or when teamwork or debate is included. This proves that students can not tell the difference between objectives and content or teaching method employed.

The analysis also shows that students identify learning objectives by using verbs like: recognize, define, enumerate, understand, present or learn. To a lesser extent, they used verbs compare, evaluate, argue, discuss, form, and differentiate, but only a very small proportion of them recognize more the most complex learning objectives by using analyse and synthesize.

Those students who replied that objectives were not achieved also stated that the pace of the lecture was too fast, the learning materials were in a foreign language or for other reasons. That is why that they could not follow the lecture.

7. **What is worth imitating**. Students evaluate teachers as worth imitating when they display competent subject knowledge and sovereignty in the delivery of class in a loud and intelligible speech. When teachers are energetic, penetrating and provide lively explanation of learning content, they stimulate students for active participation and discussion. Students admire those who offer simple explanation of interesting practical examples for better understanding of theory or ask instructive and meaningful questions at the end of lesson.

8. **Possible improvements**. Opportunities for improvements in the teaching process could, according to students, be made in the adaptation of the pace of lecture and teacher's presentation regarding audibility and voice, provision of study materials and the coordination between lectures and tutorials. They also point out that PowerPoint presentations should be prepared in compliance with the relevant recommendations.

6 CONCLUSIONS

POT offers a positive experience for the teachers observed and their peer observing teachers. It offers the observed teachers an opportunity for their self-reflection as they get both the feedback on their work and additional support from their colleagues to improve the lectures. Observers in the process of observation get the ability to obtain insight into teaching process of their colleagues with their own presence and through the perspective of students. Both views can sharpen one's perspective on their own teaching and provide students an opportunity to creatively participate in the changes in HE.

The observation also enables the exchange of experiences and views on pedagogical principles among colleagues. POT can become an important element of 'gentle' assessment, with the intention to improve teaching methods and to recognize various benefits for students. Voluntary POT can grow into a lasting 'critical' friendship, and can become teacher's constant companion through their academic career. Consequently, POT may help to establish standards of teaching at the HE institution, as it has been done at the FA, by defining what a *lecture par excellence* is.

As discussed in the results of the analysis, it has been revealed that students are most motivated in teaching and learning process when practical examples from everyday life linked with theory are made. Their involvement and active participation is increased when teamwork and ICT tools are included. Students tend to disconnect from the lecture if the pace of a lecture is too fast for them. An abundance of information in a lecture is also reported as a drawback. The results show that the teaching process could be improved if clearly defined and presented objectives and the acquired competences are briefly discussed during and after the lesson. Using stimulating pedagogical approaches, such as demonstrators, debate, teamwork or case study could encourage students to a higher level of active participation. Regular evaluation of the acquired knowledge at the end of each lecture or tutorial is considered mandatory in good teaching. A well-prepared lecturer is another important factor that increases the student motivation which can bring better achievements of students.

The studies from abroad showed that POT is used extensively to create a good climate and establish exchanges of good practices and mutual learning among teachers. Only a few foreign institutions mentioned involve students in POT who are, in fact, the final consumer of the teaching and learning process.

The results of pilot POT at the FA showed several possibilities for improvement of teaching process and POT methodology in the future. Both groups of stakeholders in the observation process, informed teachers and students, create opportunities for improvements in clearly and appropriately structured lectures and tutorials and above all, much more attention should be paid to stimulate students to take part and responsibility in the process. As the results of the pilot POT at the FA indicate that students should be the target in the observation process, clear and well defined questions should be devised and preferably, students could be trained to become excellent and interested partners in the recognition of achieving the desired objectives of learning and, consequently, the acquisition of their knowledge and competences to compete in the labour market.

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